Automated Canon-Driven Exegesis: Integrating Nītattha–Neyyattha Hermeneutics and Sutta-to-Sutta Knowledge Graphs into Dhamma-Aligned Pāli Lexicons

Author: Mahanthimulla Gamage Sarath Kumara
Email: sinhala.basaya@gmail.com · ORCID iD: 0009-0001-2144-6533
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1. Abstract

Contemporary artificial intelligence models and computational linguistic tools systematically distort Pāli canonical texts due to training data bias, over-reliance on Sanskritized etymologies, and a lack of hermeneutic awareness. This paper introduces an Automated Canon-Driven Exegesis Framework that resolves these distortions by embedding the Nītattha (ultimate, direct truth) versus Neyyattha (conventional, metaphorical) distinction directly into a filtering pipeline and a structured JSON Knowledge Base. Grounded exclusively in the Pāli–Sinhala Dictionary by Madiṭiyawela Sri Sumangala Thera (1965) and primary Pāli Suttas (such as the Nītattha/Neyyattha Suttas, Cūṭasaccaka Sutta, Vasala Sutta, Valāhaka Sutta, and Bhūmicāla Sutta), this architecture prevents secular and Brahmanical appropriations, ensuring that Pāli terms are interpreted strictly through Sakaaya Nirutti (intrinsic meaning).

2. Introduction & The Problem of Computational Distortion

Standard Large Language Models (LLMs) trained on web corpora inherit colonial and Orientalist biases, frequently mapping Pāli terms to Sanskrit equivalents (e.g., Anicca to Anitya, Gandhabba to Gandharva). This creates severe doctrinal errors.

To counteract this, our research establishes a computational architecture that forces the system to rely on Canon Interpreting Canon, bypassing external Sanskrit and secular lexicons.

3. Hermeneutic Foundation: Nītattha, Neyyattha, and Sakaaya Nirutti

The framework operationalizes the foundational directive found in the Nītattha Sutta and Neyyattha Sutta (Aṅguttara Nikāya), which categorizes texts into:

- **Neyyattha (Conventional/Metaphorical):** Terms requiring contextual interpretation (e.g., Yakkha, Valāhaka, Bhūmicāla). The system prevents these from being treated as literal physical dogma.
- **Nītattha (Ultimate Truth):** Direct doctrinal realities (Anicca, Anatta, Kusala). The system strictly blocks Sanskritized/secular definitions (such as “Annihilation” or “Impermanence as mere destruction”) and enforces Paramattha definitions.
- **Sakaaya Nirutti (Intrinsic Etymology):** Derived from principles found in the Aranavibhanga Sutta, prioritizing the organic linguistic root of the Pāli term over distorted historical corruptions.

4. Technical Architecture & Filtering Pipeline

The system operates via a multi-layered verification pipeline:

```
[User Query] → Context Classifier → [Nītattha / Neyyattha Filter] → Sutta-to-Sutta Knowledge Graph →
[Canonical Proof Output]
```

Core Rule Engine (The Five Directives & Whitelist):

- **Strict Whitelisting:** Only Madiṭiyawela Sri Sumangala Thera’s (1965) Pāli–Sinhala Dictionary and primary canonical suttas are permitted as validation sources.
- **Contextual Isolation:** If a term appears in a Neyyattha context, both conventional (Sammuti) and ultimate (Sakaaya Nirutti) meanings are rendered. If it appears in a Nītattha context, secular/Sanskrit definitions are automatically dropped (Rejected).

5. Master Dataset Schema (JSON Implementation)

The system stores verified data in a structured JSON schema, ensuring iterative expansion as new terms are identified:

```json
[
  {
    "id": "PL001",
    "pali_term": "Anicca",
    "hermeneutic_type": "Nītattha",
    "roots": "Na + Iccha (Not yielding to one's wish/desire)",
    "dictionary_ref": "Madithiyawela Sri Sumangala Pali-Sinhala Dictionary (1965)",
    "misconceptions": "සංස්කෘත 'අනිත්‍ය' (Impermanence/Destruction) ලෙස පමණක් ගැනීම",
    "sakaaya_nirutti": "රිසිස්, අභිමත පරිදි පවත්වාගත යාමට නොහැකි ස්වභාවය",
    "canonical_proof": [
      "Samyutta Nikāya - Yadniccham tam dukkham"
    ]
  },
  {
    "id": "PL002",
    "pali_term": "Yakkha",
    "hermeneutic_type": "Neyyattha",
    "roots": "Yaj (to honour, respect, worship)",
    "dictionary_ref": "Madithiyawela Sri Sumangala Pali-Sinhala Dictionary (1965)",
    "misconceptions": "ෂ් ශාන බිහිසුණු භූතයන්/රාක්ෂයන් ලෙස දැක්වීම",
    "sakaaya_nirutti": "ගෞරවයට හා පූජාවට සුදුසු උතුම් සත්ත්වයා",
    "canonical_proof": [
      "Cūṭasaccaka Sutta (MN 35)"
    ]
  }
]
```

6. Conclusion

By bridging Pāli hermeneutics (Nītattha/Neyyattha) with modern software architecture (Knowledge Graphs and Filtering Pipelines), this project provides a scalable, bias-free digital lexicon. It preserves the pristine integrity of the Buddha’s teaching while establishing a permanent digital precedent protected under open-access research repositories (Zenodo).